There was a slight pause. Then he took his blue pencil and made a large tick upon it, and passed it back to us. It was all settled in no more time than it takes to set down.[73]

It may be that Churchill could not have imagined that what he himself later called the Iron Curtain was going to be so devastating for the nations to the East of it, although he must surely have had detailed reports from Moscow about how Communism worked in practice. But one cannot escape the impression that, just as Chamberlain had been prepared to turn his back on Czechoslovakia, Churchill considered Eastern Europe a worthwhile bargain for the greater good – victory over Nazism, for which so many British lives were sacrificed too. One could also come to a further conclusion: that such an exchange would probably have not been possible had the image of a *lesser* Europe not already existed in the Western European mind.

The now infamous Yalta meeting in February 1945 confirmed the Soviet influence over Eastern Europe. Still, the clauses in the Yalta Treaty, which concerned the composition of provisional governments in Eastern Europe, were, at least in the case of Poland, differently interpreted by Churchill and Roosevelt on the one hand and Stalin on the other. While in Czechoslovakia there was genuine, large-scale public support for the local Communist party (though not for its future dictatorship), in Poland and other countries in Eastern Europe the Communists were only able to come to power because of Soviet support and manipulation or, as in the case of Yugoslavia, because of the dominance that the Communists forcibly imposed on the resistance movement. Their recognition as a legitimate force and interlocutor by the Western allies played an important role in this.

Thus while the British and Americans (with some help from various national resistance movements) liberated Western Europe and helped restore democracy there (even in Germany), large parts (though not all) of Eastern Europe, with the exception of Yugoslavia, were finally liberated by the Soviets, though with the considerable support of local resistance, Communist and non-Communist. Once their military presence was established, the Soviets certainly had no desire to help restore the institutions of liberal democracy that *had* existed, however imperfectly, in most Eastern European countries before World War II. Instead, Soviet puppet governments were established that were even obliged to refuse the generous offer of the American Marshall Plan for the aid and reconstruction